

certainly opens the door to engage in perspectives about money that are different from yours without concern of it derailing you.

The barriers we face related to our own money stories and the tests we take to learn more about ourselves are not shortcomings. It's our own implementation and attachment of meaning that makes the difference in how these things impact our lifestyles and spending decisions. The solution? Not more tests, assessments, or information, but rather the formation of a habit of curiosity.

Getting Curious

There was a time in my life when I (Jill) was regularly feeling very exhausted. For me it wasn't the kind of exhaustion or tiredness where I just needed a nap, although I'm sure that would have helped. This was more of a deep weariness that sleep wasn't touching. I knew what I was experiencing had to do with the job I held as the director of a residential program for women exiting sexually exploitative circumstances. The hours I worked were long and the emotional toll was real, but that was the extent of my understanding. Everyday tasks were cumbersome, chitchat felt like a burden, I caught myself sighing *a lot*, and all I wanted to do was isolate. So I did. I told my husband I was too tired to see friends (something I usually enjoy) and opted instead for binge-watching TV or staying even later at work thinking, "If I get more done, it will free up time" (false!). Some nights I even read a book or took a long bath. The problem was—none of those things actually resolved the deeper issue. The truth was that I was burnt out and experiencing the effects of compassion fatigue. I needed to be paying attention to my needs and the indicator signs present so that I could better aim at well-being. Instead, I responded impulsively, doing things that may or may not have brought relief to me in the past, but things I was accustomed to doing, without considering whether they actually brought care and support into place.

It was during this season that my good friend and coworker Bethann presented me with a very simple and yet remarkably profound concept. She asked, "What's the deeper need present for you? Where are you feeling the most tired?" It was a nonjudgmental, non-leading question. She was being curious with me. I admit, I did not immediately know the answer, but as I